schools were demanding high capitation fees, Fauziyya and Rasheeda met Chandrasekhar at his office on 21 June. Chandrasekhar asked S K Sharma, a labour contractor in Bangalore, for help since Sharma knew the husband of the principal of Baldwin Girls School.

A circle had been formed among the Maldivian women, Chandrasekhar, Sharma and Sasikumaran. All of them were to become accused in the spy case after inspector Vijayan bumped into Mariam in Trivandrum.

Mariam, in an interview to *Savvy Magazine*, said Vijayan made sexual advances to her after she went to inform him about the need for an extended stay in Trivandrum. She snubbed him. This was probably the reason, she alleged, that the inspector fixed her.

The CBI report on the role of certain officials of Kerala Police the investigation of ISRO espionage case says Vijayan questioned Mariam Rasheeda and Fauziyya Hassan as early as 14 October 1994, when they had approached him for getting permission for stay beyond ninety days. He told Mariam to get a confirmed ticket for her return. Accordingly, she purchased an Indian Airlines ticket to Male and another ticket to Colombo on Sri Lankan Airlines for 17 October 1994.

Vijayan, however, kept with him the tickets of Mariam Rasheeda, unauthorisedly, and on 20 October 1994 arrested her at 4:15 pm and lodged a complaint with Vanchiyoor Police Station. This formed the basis of the case against her under the Foreigners Act. The seizure of the tickets was not shown even after the registration of the case. Thus, he caused obstruction to Mariam Rasheeda's return to Male on 17 October 1994, the CBI report said.

Thaniniram evening daily reported Mariam's arrest on 20 October 1994 *Deshabhimani*, the CPI(M) mouthpiece reported it the next day, bringing in the espionage angle. Vijayan, who had discussed the 'offensive strategy' with Trivandrum city police commissioner V R Rajeevan, had by now made a valuable discovery that Mariam was a private for the Maldivian National Security Service. This was the genesis of the word 'spy' in the *Desbhabhimani* story, and later in the case itself.

The IB had already interrogated Mariam and Fauziyya, and evidently formed an opinion that spying had happened, though they had no evidence